

On autopilot

In addition to controlling parts of the body that you use deliberately, such as the muscles you need to walk and talk, your nervous system controls involuntary processes that happen without thinking, such as the beat of your heart. These involuntary processes are controlled by your autonomic nervous system (ANS).

AUTONOMIC NERVOUS SYSTEM

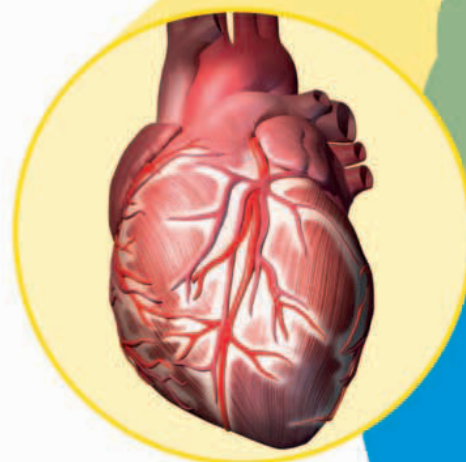
The nerve cells of the ANS run to all the main internal organs, as well as the skin, eyes, and mouth. The ANS is usually divided into two parts: one that makes the body more active, ready for action, and another that makes the body more relaxed, ready for resting.

TAKE A DEEP BREATH

You can control your breathing voluntarily, but your ANS normally does the job automatically. During exercise, when your body needs extra oxygen, your breathing rate rises and your breaths get deeper and more forceful. The sudden gasp that people make when something scares or surprises them is caused by the ANS telling the lungs to work harder.

► EYES

The ANS controls the tear glands and makes your eyes' pupils widen and constrict automatically.



▲ **HEARTBEAT** *The ANS makes your heart beat faster and more powerfully when you're physically active, excited, or frightened.*

